

CRITICAL THEORY

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Syllabus - D - Detailed, ND - Not Detailed
& For this Subject, this is not used,
For Paper II, III & IV this is used.

Imp - lessons in real are studied in each unit.

1. Unit - I -

Aristotle - Poetics

Longinus - On the Sublime

2. Unit - II

Philip Sidney - An Apology for Poetry

John Dryden - Essay on dramatic Poetry

3. Unit - III

William Wordsworth - Preface to Lyrical Ballads

S.T Coleridge - Biographia literaria, Ch. I to V

4. Unit - IV

Matthew Arnold - Study of Poetry, Functions of Criticism

T.S. Eliot - Tradition and Individual Talent

5. Unit - V

Elaine Showalter - Feminist Criticism in the Wilderness

Northrop Frye - The Function of Criticism at the present Time

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Longinus - On the SublimeSummary and Context -

One of the most influential works in history of literary criticism. It argues a timeless exploration of what makes certain passages of literature truly unforgettable. It is written in epistolary (letters) format.

Concept of Sublime according to Longinus is about a certain "loftiness and excellence of language" that "sways every reader" and produces a sense of ecstasy, wonder and elevation.

About the writer -

Era and Age - Classical Age, Greco-Roman period (c. 31 BCE - 476 CE),
1st Century CE

Titles - Father of Sublime Criticism

Admirers - Romantic poets, Wordsworth, Coleridge

Critics - Authorship Questions

Contributions -

- Developed theory of Sublimity
- Emphasized imagination and emotion
- Inspired Romantic Criticism

On the Sublime -

Before Longinus - the admitted function of poetry to instruct / to delight

- Objective of Orator or prose writer to persuade

→ Gradual, magnificence, awe and spiritual elevation
 → Reader transported beyond ordinary experience
 "The Sublime" → Something so great, beautiful, powerful or overwhelming that it inspires awe
 → Produces elevation of soul
 → Recognized by the impact it leaves

According to Longinus :-

Epics of - Homer
 Lyrics of - Sappho and Pindar
 Tragedies of - Aeschylus and Sophocles
 Speeches of - Demosthenes

were great due to their Sublimity (Sublime nature)

On the Sublime - Wonder rather than simple pleasure.

Sublime in literature is the echo of a great soul, of a lofty mind. Sublimity is a note that rings from a great mind. Sublimity lies in intensity. This is True Sublime.

→ 1. Tumidity or Bombast of language
 → 2. Purility which is parade and pomp of language
 False Sublime → 3. Cheap display of passion when it is not justified by occasion.

Way of acquiring True Sublimity -

Both nature and art are equally necessary.

"Art is perfect when it seems to be nature and nature hits the mark when she contains art hidden within her."

Five Sources of Sublime -

- | | |
|--------------------------------|-------------------|
| 1. Grandeur of Thought | } Gifts of Nature |
| 2. Strong and Inspired Passion | |
| 3. The use of figures | |
| 4. Nobility of Diction | |
| 5. Signity of Composition | |
- Products of Art

Gifts of Nature - Natural gifts of a genius

Products of Art - Achieved by regular practice of art

5 principal Sources -

1. Grandeur of Thought - Longinus links to greatness of soul.
- * Writers achieve this when they engage with noble ideas, heroic actions or universal questions. Great minds create great literature.
- * Sublime thoughts produce sublime effect. "For beautiful words are the true peculiar light of the mind."
- * "Sublimity is the echo of greatness of soul."

Example - Longinus cites several examples to illustrate the sublimity of Homer "Iliad" and he considers it superior to his "Odyssey".

Similarly there is decline in grandeur in Milton's "Paradise Regained" to "Paradise Lost".

2 Strong and Inspired Passion - The Capacity for Strong Emotions.

1 Longinus asserts that the loftiness in tone in writing contributes more than great emotions.

4 He justifies emotions more artistically than Aristotle.

Example - With this reason he preferred "Iliad" to "Odyssey" and Demosthenes to Cicero.

3 The Correct Use of Figures - Nearly one

third of the treatise has been devoted to the discussion of the figures. Used naturally, they impart elevation to style.

4 "A figure is most effective when the fact that it is a figure is concealed by splendour of style."

4 He also discusses the artistic use of many important figures of speech as an instrument for producing the sublime effect.

Chief figures are -

i) Apostrophe - Direct address to a person, thing or abstraction as in many lyrics of Shelley.

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ii) Rhetorical Question - Statement in question form that suggests its own answer.

iii) Asyndeton - Clauses, which are ordinarily connected by conjunction are left unconnected. Give passage a quick movement and reveals a sudden outburst of feelings and emotions as in Browning's Prose.

iv) Hyperbaton - Intentional inversion of word order designed for emphasis or climatic effect.

v) Polyasyndeton - Writer uses conjunction that would more than ordinarily be necessary.

vi) Periphrasis - An avoidance of blunt, direct or normal wordings for more elaborate phraseology.

4. Nobility of Diction - Choice of majestic and beautiful words. Language should be elevated.

- * Longinus said that diction should consist of correct words as well as the correct use of figures like metaphors, hyperboles and ornamented language.
- * He repeated that correct and proper words have "a moving and seductive effect."
- * Metaphor - Compares two different things by saying one thing is another thing.
Example - "Her eyes are stars"
- * Hyperbole - Extreme exaggeration used to emphasize something.
Example - "I have told you a million times."
- 5. Dignity of Composition - A writer should blend properly thought, emotion, figures and words into a harmonious whole.
- * Such an arrangement has not only a "natural power of persuasion and giving pleasure but also the marvellous power of exalting the soul and swaying the heart of men."
- * It makes the hearer or reader share

- the emotion of the speaker.
- * It includes thoughts, emotions, figures and words as the four elements of sublimity to make a harmonious whole.
 - * Need of dignified and comprehensive composition. Under this, there is stress on rhythm also.
- Longinus as a critic -
- Longinus agreed with Plato on the theory of imitation. On the other hand he agreed with Aristotle's theory of aesthetics. He admitted for the first time that pleasure is the literature.
- Scott James calls Longinus "The first romantic critic" because of his insistence in passion, ecstasy, transport, imagination, intensity and exaltation. Longinus judged a work more by its essence than by its form.
- He tempered romanticism with Classicism. He shares the classical idea that literature should have greatness, discipline and artistic skill but also emphasize the romantic side of imagination, passion and power of individual genius.

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Philip Sidney - An Apology for PoetrySummary and Context -

11/08/26 An Apology for poetry also called The Defence of Poesy is written as defence of poetry against the attacks of Stephen Gosson, a Puritan, who dedicated his pamphlet 'School of Abuse' to Sidney.

He defended poetry and proved that it deserved great name and fame. He tried to show that the main purpose of poetry should be both to instruct and delight in many ways.

About the writer -

Philip Sidney (1554-1586)

Era and Age - Elizabethan Age, 16th Century, Renaissance period (1485-1660)

Titles - Ideal Renaissance Gentleman

Admirers - Renaissance humanists, English poets

Critics - Puritans opposed his defense of poetry.

Contributions -

- First major English literary critic.
- Defended poetry against attacks.
- Popularized "Teach and delight" theory.

An Apology for Poetry -The function of Poetry -

To Aristotle poetry was an art of imitation for its natural pleasure but to Sidney it was an art of imitation with a fixed purpose because it was to "teach and delight". He added that those who practice it are called creators and prophets.

Superiority of Poetry to Philosophy and History -

Philosophy teaches by precepts while history does by example. Only but the poet makes use of virtue along with precept and example.

- * Poet teaches all persons. He does the double work of giving delight as well as teaching to the people to do good acts. He moves men to virtue in an indirect manner.

- * Poetry represents virtue in a way which is intelligible than to everybody and therefore, "The poet is the good man's tenderest stomachs, the poet is indeed the right popular philosopher."

	Philosophy	History	Poetry
Teaching	Precepts, teaches ideas	Gives facts, example	Combination of both, Vivid and Concrete examples
Virtue	Analysis and definition and by bringing general categories of virtue and vice.	By example of virtuous man from past ages	Intelligible virtue
Nature	Less attractive	Less inspiring	Delightful and effective
Appeal	Old already learned person, difficult	Tied and limited to example, limited to reality	Universal, suitable for everyone

Sidney defence to objections against poetry-

1. Objection - Poetry useless as well as waste of time

There are other more fruitful knowledges, a man may better spend his time in them than in poetry.

Defence - Poetry inspires "virtuous" actions

The aim of teaching virtues is the main aim of learning, poetry completes it better than all other arts or sciences.

- * Poetry gives both delight and instruction.

2. Objection - Poetry is "the mother of lies"

Poets spread lies

Defence - Poet does not affirm so he does not lie for the sake of telling a lie

- * Poet never affirms, therefore never lieth.

- * Poet does not claim facts, instead he creates imaginative possibilities.

- * The truths of a poet are ideal and

universal.

3. Objection - Poetry "The nurse of abuses"

Corrupts the mind of man by turning to evil. Misuses and debases the mind of man by turning it to wantonness and by making men effeminate.

Reference - Fault is not Poetry but it is with contemporary abuse of Poetry.

* Sidney added that abuse of Poetry should not lead to a charge against Poetry.

* He argues that the wit of a man does not bend to any lie by the medium of Poetry. He asserted that this charge may apply to all other sciences more than to Poetry.

4. Objection - Plato banished poets from his ideal state

Reference - Plato was against abuse of Poetry by contemporary Greek poets not against Poetry.

Plato in his 'Ion' call poet "a light and winged and sacred thing".

* Plato "Dialogues" are in form of Poetry.

Dramatic Criticism by Sidney -

Springarn remarks "Dramatic Criticism in England begin with Sir Philip Sidney"

English plays often became unrealistic and confusing because they ignore classical rules of drama.

Three unities should be maintained - Unity of Action, Time and place.

He criticizes for careless mixing of tragedy and comedy. Sidney wants drama to be morally useful.

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William Wordsworth - Preface to Lyrical Ballads

Summary and Context -

This is considered the manifesto of Romanticism. Wordsworth wrote it as an introduction to the poetry collection Lyrical Ballads, which he published with Coleridge.

22/08/26 It came to be seen as de facto manifesto of the Romantic movement. This was written to explain the aims and objective of Wordsworth's composition.

About the writer -

William Wordsworth (1770 - 1850)

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Preface to Lyrical Ballads -

The aim of preface was to define the theme and style of lyrical ballads a new kind of poems. He tried to give new values to earlier poetry in relation to his own poetry which should be understood and appreciated

properly by his readers.

Description of Poetry and its Creation Stages -

Wordsworth defines poetry as "The spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings. It takes its origin in emotions recollected in tranquility."

Poetry is the communication, not of ideas, but of emotions and whatever knowledge the poet imparts.

- * It comes from internal feelings of poet. It is a matter of feeling, mood and temperament.
- * It is generated in the heart, not in the mind. "Poetry is born out not in the mind but in the heart overflowing with feelings."
- * Poets are gifted with greater organic sensibility than ordinary individuals.

Four Stages of Poetry -

1. Observation - Of some object, person or incident which create powerful emotions in the mind of the poet.

2. Recollection - Contemplation of that emotion in tranquillity. A long period of time must pass between the stages.

3. Contemplation - Interrogation of the memory by the poet sets up or survives the emotion in "The mind itself". It is very much like first emotion but is purged of all superfluities and constitutes a stage of enjoyment.

4. Composition - Poet must convey the "overbalance of pleasure", his own "state of enjoyment" to others.

With his greater sensibility, poet communicates his experience to others in the form of poetry.

Function of Poetry - Its function is to give pleasure.

* "Poetry is the breath and finer spirit of all knowledge, the impassioned expression that is in counterpane of all sciences."

* Poetry to be worth the name, must

serve the purposes of life and morality.

Themes of Poetry - He had chosen the humble and rustic life from seasons -

- Feelings are freely and frankly expressed.
- Feelings are more simple and so are expressed more accurately and precisely.
- Manners are not sophisticated. Conducive to an understanding of human nature.
- Human passions are connected to the grand and noble objects of nature and so they are more noble and permanent.

Language of poetry - Language of rustic because such men hourly communicate with the best objects of nature from which the best part of language is derived.

Theory of Poetic Diction - Poetry is not dependent on rhetorical and literary devices; it is the free expression of poet's thoughts and feelings.